Counterfactual Attribution in Cascaded Retrieval

Progress Report, Weeks 1–2 • Anupam Dwivedi, Shubham Paliwal, Chaitanya K
CS4.406 Information Retrieval & Extraction, IIIT Hyderabad • 30 October 2026

Which stage of a two-stage cascade is responsible for its output quality? For a *pointwise* reranker, once the candidate set C_q is fixed the final ranking is invariant to the Stage-1 scores: Stage 1's only causal channel is *membership* in C_q — except under a budget, where Stage-1 rank decides who survives the cut. Score-level attribution therefore cannot answer the question, so we build four counterfactual worlds over a frozen universe U_q (actual, no-rerank, no-gate, budget) and read three non-additive estimands off them. Their sign rules hold only *conditionally on membership*, so all validation is stratified and no pooled statistic is reported.

Weeks 1 and 2 are complete. All infrastructure, data artefacts and pre-registered decisions are in place. No real Stage-2 scores exist yet; that is Week 3.

STATE

Config fingerprint	`46d0807d8ed3` (v1 = v2)
Queries / judgments	97 / 20,646
$\|U_q\|$	7,045–9,986 (med. 9,097)
Universe pairs	**872,455**
Headline K_c	100
Allocations audited	11,640
Stage-2 bill	872,455 pairs, ∼27 min
Tests passing	**415**
Commits / merged PRs	29 / 4

BM25 REPRODUCES PUBLISHED EFFECTIVENESS EXACTLY

	nDCG@10		R@1000	
	ours	pub.	ours	pub.
DL19	0.5058	0.5058	0.7501	0.7501
DL20	0.4796	0.4796	0.7863	0.7863

Delta 0.0000 on all four. This is the only check that verifies the run is *right* rather than well formed, and it gates the handoff. The universe was reproduced bit-identical in three environments across two operating systems, demonstrating most of the Week-4 reproducibility requirement early.

1. Work completed

Shared (224 tests): engine, world and budget runners, effects, membership strata, stratified metrics, schemas, provenance. **Anupam** (145 tests): loaders and the by-query split, retriever interface, BM25 run and verifier, the frozen universe, the feasibility gate, Stage-1 over U_q, the reference subset and the t-allocations with audits. **Shubham** (46 tests): DPR Stage-1 run, the counterfactual engine, E1 exact-recovery validation, the H7 power simulation, effect analysis, condensed-mode support. **Chaitanya** (25 tests, in PR): reranker wrapper, cache filler, features, predictors, cost–fidelity harness, shard plan, GPU throughput and the shuffle-invariance test.

2. Key results

Feasibility gate passed. Candidate Jaccard 0.11–0.16, so the two Stage-1 systems select genuinely different documents and the cross-paradigm comparison has leverage. The expected confound — TREC pools favouring lexical runs — does *not* exist: judged density of C_q is 1.06× between systems, and the Stage-1 floor is symmetric at an identical 0.450 for both. Outsider-policy supply is 40–49× the budget, so `boundary` and `alternative` are real policies rather than tie-breaks in disguise.

Cost is not a constraint. The cache keys on (query, doc) and every world re-ranks a subset of U_q, so the whole project costs 872,455 calls *once* — a measured 27-minute job at 535 pairs/sec. This retired the reference-subset sampling design entirely. Shuffle-invariance passed on the real reranker, verifying rather than assuming the pointwise property the E_{gate} derivation rests on.

H7 is confirmatory for one policy only. At K_c=100 and the real $|U_q|$, no subset smaller than all 97 queries reaches 0.80 power, and even then only `alternative` clears it (0.935/0.875); `boundary` falls short (0.67/0.41). Declared descriptive in advance.

3. Corrections — the fortnight's most valuable output

Five defects were found in shared code, **four of them in checks that passed while being structurally unable to detect the failure they existed to catch**: the H7 power denominator conditioned on testability and so overstated power; "relevant" counted grade-1 documents that carry zero gain, inflating the gate-failure supply 4–9× and nearly deciding the headline K_c from the wrong number; the BM25 verifier used exponential gain where `trec_eval` uses linear, so it would have "verified" against an unreachable number; and the allocation spend check compared against the amount *achieved*, so a short allocation matched its own shortfall. Separately, our own pre-declared headline-K_c rule conflated a non-degeneracy floor with a selection rule and so chose the depth with *least* signal; the correction is recorded as post-hoc, defensible only because supply is measurable before any effect exists. A sixth, open: Stage-2 features built over all of U_q do not approximate e_{gate} for a non-survivor, they *determine* it.

4. Open validity threat, and how it is handled

U_q is 1.65% judged while BM25's top-100 is 51% judged. World C sorts ∼9,000 mostly-unjudged documents, so judged survivors are displaced out of its top-10 and E_{gate} drifts towards DCG(π_{act}) as an artefact of 2019 pooling. Resolved *procedurally* at freeze v2: every effect is computed both uncondensed and condensed (Sakai, SIGIR 2007). Condensing transforms rankings, not scores, so it costs no extra GPU calls, and it is the only option that does not decide before the evidence exists. The uncondensed estimand stays primary; a disagreement is itself a finding.

5. Future work

Week 3. *Blocking:* the feature-leakage fix in PR #3, after which the synthetic fidelity numbers must be regenerated. Then fill the cache under the shard plan; compute E_{rerank}, E_{gate} and Δ_t over the real universe in both modes; and take the decisive measurement — if world C's top-10 is ∼20% unjudged the concern is a footnote, if ∼95% the condensed figure becomes the headline. **Week 4.** Effect distributions by stratum, the cost–fidelity curve (which must converge to the exact reference at full budget), the H7 comparison, predictor fidelity against all three baselines, and the reproducibility pack.

Known risks. Judgment sparsity is mitigated procedurally, not solved; H7 is descriptive for `boundary` at any feasible size; and gate-failure supply is thin even at the headline depth (median 6, with 17–23 of 97 queries having none), so per-query distributions will be noisy and must be reported with their supply.

Repository `a-n-u-p-a-m/IRE_PROJECT`; reasoning for every decision, and an extended version of this report, in `docs/`.